actually ancient Tamil words that found their way into Sanskrit. We will see how such exchange continued into subsequent centuries as with the spread of Shakti worship emanating from the east or with Shankaracharya's ideas from the far south. Of course there are significant regional variations, but these are small compared to what is shared with India's wider civilization.

Instead of using it to split hairs over regional differences, I would say that Sangam literature is far more remarkable for the extraordinary continuities it shows us that remain alive today. For instance, one of the Sangam poems gives us a glimpse of Madurai as it was under Pandyan king Neduchelyan. We are told of the stalls near the temple selling sweetmeats, garlands of flowers and betel paan. The bazaars were full of goldsmiths, tailors, coppersmiths, flower-sellers, painters and vendors of sandalwood. It is astonishing, two thousand years later, how well this would describe a temple-town of today.

THE WORLD OF THE *PERIPLUS*

The world described above was at the heart of a mercantile network that extended from the Mediterranean to the South China Sea. The single most important factor that allowed this boom in trade was an understanding of monsoon-wind patterns, a discovery that Greek sources credit to a navigator called Hippalus. The discovery allowed merchant fleets to sail directly across the Arabian Sea rather than hug the coast. As a result, Greek, Roman, Jewish and Arab traders flocked to Indian ports even as Indian merchants made their way to the Persian Gulf, the Red Sea and even down the East African coast. We know a significant amount about these trade routes because an unknown Greek writer has left us a detailed manual called the *Periplus Maris Erythraei*.[4]

According to the *Periplus*, the port of Berenike was a key hub in the trading network. It was located on the Red Sea coast of Egypt and had been established by the Ptolemies, the Greek dynasty that was founded in Egypt by one of Alexander's generals. Archaeological excavations in the nineties have confirmed its location.[5] Goods from India landed here and were then